

Transatlantic relations inch back from the precipice

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Despite the occasionally contradictory messaging around Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff's recent trip to Russia, US policy toward the war in Ukraine is more aligned with that of European allies and Kyiv than at the beginning of President Donald Trump's second term.

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Trade and tech policy are currently the main flash points in transatlantic relations because of the mismatch in the US and European framings of recent fines against US tech firms and tariffs threatened in response.

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The risk of a US pullback from NATO and renewed threats against Greenland has declined, though both remain important potential points of friction if Trump grows more volatile in response to his weakening domestic position in the closing years of his term.

Transatlantic relations are stabilizing at a low level. Worst-case scenarios such as a US pullout from NATO, abandonment of Ukraine, and removal of security forces in Europe have not materialized, as we expected (see Trump's NATO threats will erode US leadership and burden Europe , 13 April 2026). Expanded European defense spending, Ukrainian battlefield success, and frustrations with Russia have created a more stable floor in transatlantic ties. We expect that the US will continue along this path, though Trump's regular public interventions—aimed mostly at a domestic audience—will keep anxiety high in European capitals.

However, not getting worse doesn't mean getting better. The political friction and fall in trust in transatlantic ties remain. The EU's understandable tendency to take the most bellicose and bombastic statements from the White House as definitive and discount the signals transmitted by officials such as CIA director John Ratcliffe—now the key interlocutor on Russia and Ukraine issues—limits the room for improvement.

Greenland has moved from an acute crisis to a managed point of tension. Our basecase remains a negotiated arrangement, centered on US basing rights and offensive weapons deployment authority, rather than any formal transfer of Greenland's sovereignty. Trump is constrained by a cohesive European pushback and a sharply negative US public reaction to his threats to seize Greenland. However, a likely midterm loss would increase the chance of a volatile response from Trump.

Negotiations will continue, albeit slowly, and the deep distrust engendered by Trump's initial push will endure.

Incremental US pivot on Ukraine is a source of stability. US policy toward the war in Ukraine is now more aligned with that of its European allies and Kyiv, a shift that has occurred primarily over the last eight months. The change has been incremental rather than absolute and is more visible in the operational aspects of US policy than the White House's public messaging. Witkoff and Kushner's recent trip to Moscow and Kyiv illustrates that pattern: Though their positive comments toward Russian President Vladimir Putin appeared to revert to the early 2025 approach, their engagement with Volodymyr Zelensky, coordination with European security officials, and discussion of support for Ukraine to sustain its defense through the winter point to a more aligned policy in practice. Ratcliffe's elevation in engagement with Russia and his successful push to expand US intelligence support for long-range Ukrainian strikes also reflect this shift. Ratcliffe's recent trip to Russia is another example: the trip was pre-planned, coordinated with allies, and used to both keep a line of communication open and to warn the Russians off escalation (see Ratcliffe's Moscow trip likely a warning and a backchannel , 27 August 2026.).

Trade miscommunication and tech policy are the two biggest risks. EU fines totaling €890 million (\$1 billion) on Google under the Digital Markets Act, along with the recently announced US Section 301 tariff investigations in response, pose the most immediate risk of escalation. At the center of the dispute is a sharp difference in how each side frames the issue, with each believing its actions do not violate the existing Turnberry trade agreement (see White House digital probe will target EU exports not firms , 27 August 2026). The main watchpoints are an acceleration of the Section 301 investigation, which is currently unlikely to advance before the second half of 2027; US threats of tariffs on individual EU tech companies; and EU signals that future fines may be more limited.

Deployment of EU and China trade tools could affect the US. In the third quarter, the EU is expected to present an overcapacity instrument aimed at targeting China's trade surplus. However, the tool is designed to apply to any country, so it could also be deployed against US firms, though it probably won't be ready for use until early 2028. Meanwhile, China's Regulation 834/835 compounds risks for US multinationals with China exposure by creating a conflict with the EU measures. As a result, US firms could have their supply chains investigated by both the EU and China.

European dependence on US LNG is one of the relationship's most durable stabilizers. The US is now the EU's largest LNG supplier, accounting for 57% of imports in 2025, a share that's likely to grow after the 1 January 2027 halt to European purchases of Russian LNG. For Trump, energy purchases are a notable show of political alignment and create incentives for continued alignment with Europe. EU member states' push to expand electrification and renewable deployment as a hedge against LNG use is unlikely to undermine this dynamic, as Europe will still need gas for its reindustrialization plans.

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

Mujtaba Rahman

Managing Director, Europe

+44 (0) 207.553.9823

rahman@eurasiagroup.net

Alexander Kolyandr

Director, Europe

kolyandr@eurasiagroup.net

Nick Reiners

Senior Analyst, Geo-technology

reiners.ne@eurasiagroup.net

EG United States

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

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